



Research Article

The Coming End of Don Politics in Sri Lanka

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Abstract

This article examines the rise and declines of the social class that emerged in the low-country regions of Sri Lanka following the consolidation of Portuguese power in 1505, became further strengthened during the Dutch period, gained greater stability under British rule, and ultimately captured state power after 1948. The social layer known as the Mudaliyar class originated under Portuguese administration by surpassing the long-standing caste-based hierarchical framework that had existed in Sri Lanka for centuries. Embracing Catholicism and receiving extensive land grants, this group adopted the Portuguese honorific Dom, later modified to Don during the Dutch era. Under British rule, members of the Kandyan 'Radala' elite were incorporated into this social formation. Through strategic intermarriage, these two groups consolidated into a single class whose economic power and social prestige enabled them to maintain state power from 1948 to 2024. In this article, the term Don politics refers to the political dominance of this elite class.

Although two 'subordinate' leaders assumed state leadership in 1988 and 2015, these shifts failed to significantly challenge the long standing structures of Don politics. What occurred in 2024, however, represents following Antonio Gramsci's conceptualization—a transfer of state power from the Don elite to the subordinate, with the intervention of the country's organic intellectuals. This transformation does not necessarily represent the emergence of a subaltern authoritarianism or a shift from neoliberalism to socialism. Rather, it indicates that the historic aristocratic political order has been fundamentally destabilized. This does not imply that Don politics has entirely ended or cannot re-emerge in the future; however, at this particular historical moment, it stands strongly challenged.

Keywords: Don politics, Mudaliyar class, power transition, subordinate, Determinate Time

Introduction This article is based on the Master of Philosophy dissertation titled New Trends in Political Leadership and Dominant Patterns in Sri Lanka, submitted to the Postgraduate Institute of the University of Sri Jayewardenepura in 2017.

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During the extended discussion of political history and leadership patterns in Sri Lanka, a significant observation emerged: except for two moments—1948 to 2015—the political dominance and control of state power in Sri Lanka have largely remained with the Mudaliyar class that originated during the Portuguese period in the low-country, later linked with the Kandyan Radala elite.

A central sociological question arises when discussing elites in Sri Lanka: Who are the elites globally or universally, and who are the elites in Sri Lanka? As classical German sociologist Georg Simmel (1907/2008) observes, within a constantly changing and irreducible social system, this formation can only be understood through another conceptual lens—*aristocracy*. Simmel conceptualizes aristocracy not as a historically confined European or “feudal” socio-cultural construct, but as a universal concept that encompasses complex social and political groupings. This implies that elites in any society can be understood as aristocratic formations.

According to Jakob Rosell (2017), the aristocrats of Sri Lanka may be identified as the *Radala*. Rosell argues that the *Radala* embodied a commitment to safeguarding their autonomy and, when required, serving the king and the state. Thus, the *Radala* stood above narrow ethnic, religious, regional, and linguistic communities (Rosell, 2017, p. 18). In Sri Lankan history, the *Radala* represent the highest sub caste of the ‘*Govigama*’ caste within the hierarchical order (Peiris, Ralph, 1964/2005). They formed the elite administrative class linked to the Kandyan Kingdom. However, the elites under discussion here are not the Kandyan *Radala*; rather, they are the group that emerged from the middle and lower castes of the low country, gaining prominence during Portuguese rule.

This group, being economically empowered under Portuguese rule, later became known as the *Mudaliars* or the *Mudaliyar class*. Members of the *Mudaliyar class* adopted the Portuguese honorific *Dom*, which evolved into *Don* during the Dutch period and eventually gained legal recognition. In this article, *Don politics* refers not only to this group but to the broader political culture and power structure of the entire elite formation.

Methodology

The central research question guiding this study was: *Can shifts in political leadership and dominance patterns in Sri Lanka be explained solely through elite–subordinary theoretical frameworks, or are there other political-sociological factors at play?* The primary objective was to address a theoretical gap within Sri Lankan political sociology by identifying the dominant social structures influencing state power and by evaluating how these structures shape political leadership. Under a purposeful sampling strategy, 60 participants were selected: 20 political leaders directly engaged in politics, 19 socio political activists, and 21 professionals and civil society representatives. Due to overseas commitments, administrative constraints, and coordination difficulties, approximately 20% of the selected informants could not participate, and no alternative sample was added. Thus, 80% of the originally selected participants served as active data sources.

Given the predominantly qualitative orientation of the study, data collection methods included in-depth interviews, semi-structured interviews, and life-history approaches. Additionally, library research and secondary data sources were utilized. Thematic analysis was employed to analyze the data. The empirical fieldwork was conducted from May 2015 to April 2016, covering a full year, while subsequent analysis also incorporated secondary data up to the present.

Theoretical Background

To theoretically understand *Don Politics* in Sri Lanka, this section mainly utilizes Vilfredo Pareto’s theory of the circulation of elites and Antonio Gramsci’s theory of hegemony. If we analyze the evolution of Sri Lanka’s political system—especially the diffusion from the elite-dominated “Don Politics” to grassroots and subordinary political power formations—through the lens of Vilfredo Pareto’s (1935) theory of the circulation of elites, “the elite stratum refers to a small group of individuals who have succeeded in various fields of activity and reached the higher levels of the professional hierarchy. Such elites can be categorized as governing elites and non-governing elites; the governing elite

directly or indirectly performs significant functions in government. Pareto's main discussion centers on the governing elite, and between governing and non-governing elites there exists a circulation. When the governing elite becomes weak, capable individuals within the non-governing elite rise into the governing elite. This replacement process occurs in two ways: either through a gradual, orderly infiltration or, when blocked, through violent revolution. Accordingly, the economic liberalization that emerged in Sri Lanka after 1977, the swelling of the middle class, and the upward mobility of subordinate rural micro-political actors together make this theoretical foundation highly productive in understanding how *Don Politics* and elite political dominance came under increasing challenge.

According to Antonio Gramsci (1971), intellectuals are central to the concept of hegemony or domination. Gramsci identifies intellectuals as the key actors within elite classes, responsible not only for maintaining dominance through coercion but also for shaping society's consent via cultural and ideological leadership. Thus, the stability of elite dominance relies as much on cultural and ideological authority as on force. In this context, Gramsci defines intellectuals as those who perform intellectual functions within the division of social labor (Gunasinghe, 2011, p. 119). Gramsci argues that intellectuals have historically played a role in enterprises aimed at acquiring state power. Since intellectuals can emerge both within the ruling (elite) class and working class, they cannot be considered a distinct class in themselves. To analyze the activities of specific intellectual strata, Gramsci introduces the concept of "organic intellectuals. Gunasinghe (2011, p. 121) explains that Gramsci divides organic intellectuals into two categories: 1. Those who work directly with the current ruling elite class, representing and reinforcing the ideology of the elite, and 2. Those who, while engaging with the subordinate classes particularly the laboring population align themselves with the subordinate class poised to assume power in the future, thereby articulating and representing its ideology. However, Gramsci emphasizes that organic intellectuals can only emerge in relation to existing class formations: the current ruling elite and the subordinate class preparing to assume future power, not independently of these class structures.

The Sri Lanka's traditional elite dominant hegemony has been challenged at various times, in 2024 the rural subordinate population, rather than through revolution, overturned the traditional dominance of *Don Politics* almost entirely through the electoral process. To understand this situation, post Marxist theorists such as Laclau and Mouffe (1985) emphasize that power and resistance are interlinked, and that counter-hegemonic movements emerge within discursive and symbolic structures that allow such challenges to form. They argue that "the existing configuration of any society is a temporary arrangement in which diverse power relations have been given meaning; it is always open to challenge, and ideology is continually re-articulated. This makes clear that power and hegemony are never fixed but continuously re-defined through new struggles and debates.

Within this context, the emergence of rural level leaders and subordinate mobilizations can be understood through post-Marxist and subaltern perspectives particularly those of Ranajit Guha (1982) calls the small voice of history. For a long period, the historiography of Indian nationalism was dominated by elitism; both colonial elitism and national elitism shared the same bias. Thus, the electoral revolution of 2024 can be read as a symbolic and structural transformation that challenges Sri Lanka's traditional elite political order.

Historical Development of Don Politics in Sri Lanka

Looking at the historical political development of Sri Lanka, the feudal system that existed under various kings for over 2,300 years collapsed with the arrival of the Portuguese in 1505. This marked a decisive turning point in the island's economic, social, and political history. The pre-existing socio-economic system was gradually replaced by an export-oriented commercial economy. To sustain this economy, land required for export-oriented plantations was acquired from traditional temple lands, village lands, and other communal holdings. Portuguese settlers were granted ownership of these lands, giving rise to a new social class of landowners known as the *Casados*. (De Silva, 1994, pp. 6–7). By 1619, this class had captured one in every five villages in the Kotte kingdom.

At the same time, large tracts of land were granted to Sinhalese who showed strong loyalty to the Portuguese, thereby creating a new Lankan social class that possessed both land and political influence. This social class gained not only through conversion to Catholicism but also through education in missionary schools established by the Portuguese, which allowed them access to additional privileges. Every aspect of life in this class including language, food habits, and other cultural practices was transformed, and as a mark of this cultural revolution, members added the honorific “Dom” to their names. When Lorenzo de Almeida¹ arrived in Sri Lanka in 1505, one of his objectives was to promote Catholicism throughout the island. By 1557, under King Jayoo Periya Bandara of Kotte, the practice of conferring the name “Dom Juwan Jayoo Dharmapala Periya Bandara” (1541–1597) during childhood began as a form of recognition (Wright, A.1999, p, 45). According to the Portuguese, “Dom” represented the highest honorific title. Consequently, many members of this newly emerging social class voluntarily adopted the title “Don” with their names. During the Dutch period, the term continued to be used, while for women, it was applied as “Dona”(Singer, M.R.1964, p,22).

The Dutch, during their administration, further developed and institutionalized the commercial wealth system that had begun under the Portuguese, addressing the structural and organizational shortcomings that the Portuguese had left unfulfilled. They maintained plantation based cultivation of cinnamon as the primary production method but transformed labor relations from the earlier feudal-style system to a contract based labor system (Jayawardena Kumari, 2008, pp, 3–4). Caste analysis of this new elite reveals that it was dominated not by the traditional high caste *Govigama* (farmers), but by middle caste groups such as *Karava* (Fisherman), *Salagama* (Cinnamon shakers) and *Durawa* (Toddy tapper) who acquired social and economic power through Portuguese support. The destruction of temples, Buddhist practices, and customary regulations by the Portuguese disrupted traditional agrarian structures, creating new social mobility for lower castes. *Salagama* caste members became cinnamon merchants, *Karava* castes became shipbuilders, sailors, and coastal traders, while *Durawa* caste members became involved in tax collection, arrack export, and coconut cultivation, thus gaining wealth and social prominence (Rosel, J. 2017, p, 22). The *Navandanna* (Iron workers) caste also rose in social rank through its role in iron supply. Additionally in this period the arrack (alcohol) industry became a lucrative new commercial enterprise (Hemachandra, 2005, pp. 3). The rise of plantation and arrack based commercial enterprises generated unprecedented wealth for these middle castes. According to Jacob Rosel (2017), this new class did not restrict itself to traditional caste occupations but actively participated in all lucrative economic activities, trade, and investment opportunities, accumulating substantial wealth. By the early nineteenth century, the ‘*Mudaliar*’ class in the low country had established itself as the dominant social stratum (Peebles, 1995, p. 03). The Portuguese had granted the colonial governor permission to appoint Sinhalese Catholic elites from village headmen to high-ranking positions, creating a cadre of *Mudaliars* who exercised both economic and administrative authority (Peebles, 1995, p. 29).

With the British takeover in 1796, the Mudaliar class in the low country was coopted into colonial administration to maintain continuity of governance. Unlike in the up-country, where Radala aristocracy retained autonomy, the low country Mudaliars adapted to British authority and expanded their influence. By the late nineteenth century, middle caste elites in the commercial economy secured recognition and privileges from the British, reinforcing their socio-economic and political power (Peebles, 1995, pp. 78–79). Under British colonial rule, administrative control continued in the same framework established by the Portuguese and Dutch. The Mudaliyar class was embedded in centralized colonial structures, maintaining authority through indigenous subordinate officers under local department heads until the British abolished the system in 1938 (Peebles, 1995, p. 03). This shows that by the second decade of the sixteenth century, the Don named Mudaliyar class had already consolidated political authority at a high level.

The 1929 constitutional reforms, which expanded suffrage and introduced a representative system of governance, impacted both the up country and low country elites by encouraging them to organize in order to maintain their socio-economic dominance. At the same time, they appealed to the Sinhalese peasantry, subordinated under plantation

¹ Dom Lourenço de Almeida, the son of the Crown Prince of Cochin, was such a brave sailor that, at the age of 18, he was appointed captain in charge of the Indian Ocean. While voyaging toward the Maldives, he was forced by bad weather to take shelter at the port of Galle

capitalism, to garner political support. The Lanka National Congress provided the ideological basis, promoting a unified Sinhalese Buddhist political vision grounded in the motherland, ethnicity, and religion (Rosel, 2017, pp. 27-28). Through universal suffrage and secret ballots, colonial governors transferred power to this emerging social elite, laying the foundation for a powerful Sinhalese Buddhist nationalism after independence.

By the late 1940s, prominent elite families such as the Senanayake, Bandaranaike, and Jayewardene had consolidated authority as leading national elites, reinforcing political control through kinship, marriage, and party networks (Jeggings. J, 1979, P, 22). According to Marshall R. Singer (1964), this elite dominated the 1924 State Council, the 1931 and 1936 Legislative Councils, and the governments of 1947 and 1951 without significant challenge. Following Bandaranaike's victory in 1956, a new elite emerged aligned with Sinhalese Buddhist nationalism. While this group emphasized nationalism, it largely represented the Anglicized upper class and functioned primarily as a middle-class elite whose influence rested on expressing middle-class values in Sinhalese (Rosel, 2017, p. 28). Between 1960–1965 and 1970–1977, political leadership included Sirimavo Bandaranaike, from the Up-country Ratwatte Radala family allied to the Bandaranaike, serving as head of state, and Dudley Senanayake, son of D. S. Senanayake, serving as Prime Minister from 1965–1970.

Thus, even prior to independence, this coalition economically privileged, socially established, and politically united had created a strong foundation to maintain dominance. After Sri Lanka gained dominion status in 1948, this social elite secured economic power, social dominance, and twentieth-century political leadership. In this article, the term “Don” refers not only to those bearing the title but to this Mudaliyar class that acquired political authority in independent Sri Lanka.

The Ascendancy of Don Politics, 1948–1989

Through political reform initiatives, the Lanka National Congress, mercantile enterprises, and Buddhist revival movements, the groups that had secured power in the State Council in 1931 successfully consolidated control over the first Parliament in 1947 with relative ease. The leading figure of that period was D. S. Senanayake, the Prime Minister of the 1947 government, also known as Don Stephen Senanayake. The Health and Provincial Administration Minister of that government were S. W. R. D. Bandaranaike, Solomon West Ridgeway Dias Bandaranaike, whose early generation members were commonly referred to as “Don.” The Finance Minister was J. R. Jayewardene, Junius Richard Jayewardene, son of Eugene Wilfred Jayewardene. The patriarch of this family cartel was considered to be ‘*Maha muddily*’ (Chief Muddier) Don Adrian Jayewardene. In this manner, it is very clear that the complete power of the first government of independent Sri Lanka, as well as political dominance in the country, was consolidated by this Don family cartel².

The Senanayake Family Cartel

D. S. Senanayake, appointed as the first Prime Minister of Sri Lanka in 1948, was the son of Don Bartholomeus Senanayake. He was born in the Hapitigama Korale of the Negombo district, Lower Botale village. At the age of 18, he reportedly began a graphite business, which proved highly successful, allowing him to invest in coconut estates, urban property, and liquor-related trade (Jayewardene & Kumari, 2008, p. 241). He was also a member of the “Colombo Liquor Traders’ Association.” The family became prominent in the political arena during the 20th century, and D. S.

² The term “**family cartel**” is used in Kumari Jayawardena’s work ‘*Sokkan Lokkan U Wuyi*’ (No body Some) to refer to similar social groups. For example, it is applied to a member of the Lese the Arrack bootleggers’ cartel” (2008, p. 242). However, when referring to family-based groups, she uses terms such as “**family network**,” “**family group**,” or “**family chain**” instead of “cartel” (p. 246). Similarly, Victor Ivan, in his work *Family and Caste in Politics*, uses the term to mean a group of interconnected families.

Senanayake's three sons—Don Charles Senanayake, F. R. G. Senanayake, and D. S. Senanayake—gained renown in mercantile ventures (Jayewardene, 2008, pp. 241–242).

This made D. S. Senanayake a very wealthy member of the landed gentry, and the family further consolidated influence through blood relations and marriages with four other prominent families: the Wijewardene, Wickremasinghe, Corea, and Kotawala families (Nsata, 1979, p. 111). D. S. Senanayake married Molly Dunuwila, daughter of the distinguished Upcountry Dunuwila family, a strategic alliance that followed the common practice of using marriage to consolidate social status (Jayewardene, 2008, p. 242). D. S. Senanayake was succeeded as Prime Minister by his son Dudley Senanayake. Other family members included J. R. Jayewardene, who became Sri Lanka's first executive President, and the connections of his father, E. W. Jayewardene, through marriage with Agnes Wijewardene, daughter of the British-era entrepreneur Don Philip Tudugala Wijewardene, linking them to other elite families, including the current Prime Minister Ranil Wickremasinghe (De Silva & Riggins, 1997, pp. 38–39).

The Bandaranaike Family Cartel

The other dominant Don family cartel in Sri Lanka was the Bandaranaike. S. W. R. D. Bandaranaike, son of Chief Muddier Solomon West Ridgeway Dias Bandaranaike, descended from a line that played a key role in historical agreements and governance. The patriarch, Don William Dias, acted as interpreter for the British Governor during the signing of the Kandyan Convention and is regarded as the earliest prominent figure of this lineage (Rutnam, J. T. 2010, p. 4).

The founding ancestor of this generation, *Neela Perumal*, also known as *Kalu Kapuruge*, served as the chief priest of the *Nawagamuwa* Temple around 1590³. A Dravidian from India, he was brought to Sri Lanka to construct the temple and later became its first chief. He married a South Indian Dravidian woman, and their children adopted the surname Kalu Kapuruge instead of Neela Perumal. Subsequent generations used the title '*Pandaram Nayaka*' (Chief priest in the temple), eventually transliterated into Sinhala as Bandaranaike (Dissanayake, S. B. 2009, pp. 7–8). Later generations, including Mohotti Appuhami (1625) and Don Francisco Dias Wijetunga Bandaranaike (1720), further established the family in administrative positions, consolidating power among mercantile and landholding elites by the 19th century (Rutnam, 2010, pp. 3–4). Through marriage alliances with other influential families, such as the Molamure, Alwis, Sirivardana, and Peiris families, the Bandaranaiques reinforced their social and political status. Under S. W. R. D. Bandaranaike's leadership, the Lanka National Congress successfully mobilized the majority Sinhala Buddhist electorate, establishing him as the political leader most attuned to Sinhala Buddhist ideology. In 1952, he founded the Sri Lanka Freedom Party, promising a "renewal of radical social transformation that prioritizes indigenous aspirations and the values of Sinhala villagers" (Jiggins, J. 1979, p. 101). His 1956 electoral victory is regarded as a 'silent revolution', (Coomaraswamy, 1988, p. 32). bringing individuals from lower socio-economic backgrounds into Parliament and altering the traditional elite order (Gunasinghe, 2006, pp. 41–57).

The Jayewardene Family Cartel

The patriarch of this line is considered Don Adrian Wijesinghe Jayewardene, also known as Thrombi Mudali, (1768–1830), originating from a Chetty family that migrated from coastal India during the early Dutch period. He married into the local Jayewardene family, establishing the modern Jayewardene lineage (De Silva & Riggins, 1997, pp. 21, 24). J. R. Jayewardene, who achieved a decisive victory in the 1977 parliamentary elections, became Sri Lanka's first executive President. He introduced a liberal economic system, replacing the state-centered agricultural economy maintained from the D. S. Senanayake government of 1947 through Sirimavo Bandaranaike's administration in 1970.

Through these family networks—Senanayake, Atigala, Kotawala, Corea, Jayewardene, and Wijewardene—elite Don families maintained political dominance and ensured their authority across successive post-independence decades. From

³ "It is a well-known Paththini Hindu temple in Sri Lanka, located in Nawagamuwa, Colombo District."

the 1931 State Council period to 1989, it is evident that political power in Sri Lanka remained consolidated under this Don family cartel (Jayewardene & Kumari, 2008, p. 441).

The so-called fourth political upheaval in Sri Lanka unfolded with the election of Ranasinghe Premadasa as President in 1988. For the first time, the dominance of Don-style political leadership—marked by elite patronage networks, aristocratic lineage, and English-educated privilege—was displaced by a non-elite leader. Premadasa's ascent, grounded in lower-caste Sinhalese origins rather than elite kinship, represented a radical departure from the established order. His rise from the lowest tier of the Sinhala caste hierarchy to the presidency was unprecedented, symbolizing a moment of collective pride and aspiration for the socially marginalized classes (Ivan, 2015, p. 145).

Premadasa's non-elite background extended beyond caste. Unlike the Western-educated elite who had dominated Sri Lankan politics since independence, he hailed from a modest family, was educated locally in Sinhala medium schools, and lacked the cultural and linguistic capital traditionally associated with ruling elites. His limited English fluency—often mocked by the Colombo establishment—became, paradoxically, a mark of authenticity among the working-class and rural voters. Like S. W. R. D. Bandaranaike's 1956 revolution, Premadasa's rise reflected a form of political mobilization that bypassed elite mediation and drew strength from mass participation. Yet, his tenure was violently interrupted by the LTTE's assassination in 1993, signaling that his political breakthrough was not an anomaly but a symptom of deeper structural shifts in Sri Lankan society.

Following Premadasa's death, Dingiri Banda Wijetunga—another non-elite figure from a middle-class background in Kandy District—assumed the presidency. Wijetunga's political career, beginning as a police constable, further reflected the temporary erosion of traditional elite dominance. As (Uyangoda (2008, p. 51) notes, however, these moments of non-elite leadership were exceptions rather than signs of a fundamental transformation in the elite political order. In 1994, Chandrika Bandaranaike Kumaratunga's ascent to the presidency once again reaffirmed the endurance of dynastic politics. Despite her initial populist appeal, her tenure revealed the persistent tension between Sinhalese Buddhist nationalism and elite-centered governance echoing earlier cycles of reform and restoration witnessed in 1956, 1977, and 1989.

The Rajapaksa Family Cartel

Although the Rajapaksa family belonged to the Govigama caste, their power base differed from the Westernized Colombo aristocracy. As Roberts (1997) observes, they emerged as a regional, indigenous elite grounded in the agrarian and cultural traditions of Ruhuna in southern Sri Lanka. Mahinda Rajapaksa's father, Don Alwin Rajapaksa (D. A. Rajapaksa), was a founding member of the Sri Lanka Freedom Party (SLFP) in 1951, following his defection from Parliament alongside S. W. R. D. Bandaranaike (Banduthilaka, 2001, p.17). Mahinda thus inherited a political lineage inseparable from the SLFP's origins.

Chandrika Bandaranaike Kumaratunga initially resisted endorsing Rajapaksa as the SLFP's presidential candidate. However, despite being outside the Bandaranaike–Ratwatte elite nexus, Rajapaksa secured the nomination and won the 2005 presidential election—a turning point that marked the displacement of Colombo's traditional dynastic dominance (Ivan, 2015). The Rajapaksas' political genealogy extended further. Mahinda's grandfather, Don Matthew Rajapaksa (D. M. Rajapaksa), had served in the State Council representing Hambantota's rural cultivators. In 1931, he petitioned Parliament on behalf of 1,125 members of the Naketi caste, demanding their right to wear upper garments and carry umbrellas privileges historically denied under caste hierarchy (Ileperuma, 2005). This early act of subaltern advocacy foreshadowed the family's later image as champions of rural and lower caste empowerment. Mahinda Rajapaksa first entered Parliament in 1970 representing Beliatta and later held multiple high offices—Leader of the Opposition (2001–2003), Prime Minister (2004–2005), and Executive President (2005–2014). His presidency reached its zenith with the military defeat of the LTTE in 2009, celebrated across the Sinhala-Buddhist South not merely as a military triumph but

as a civilizational victory (Wellawatte, 2017). Yet, this triumph must also be read as the ideological reassertion of Sinhala-Buddhist hegemony.

Mick Moore (1989, 2008) identifies three core assumptions underlying this nationalism: (1) Sri Lanka as a historically unique Sinhala-Buddhist nation; (2) an essential racial and linguistic distinction between Arya-Sinhalese and Dravidian minorities; and (3) an ingrained distrust toward Tamil-speaking Dravidians (Moore, 2008, p. 190). Within this ideological frame, the end of the war was perceived as the vindication of Sinhala-Buddhist civilization. Across southern villages, people lit bonfires, cooked *kiribath*, and declared, “Now we can live freely”—a symbolic reaffirmation of cultural dominance. Thousands travelled to Jaffna not merely as tourists but as symbolic claimants of national territory, asserting, “We defeated you; now this land is ours.”

Mahinda Rajapaksa thus became the embodiment of Sinhala nationalist leadership—fusing populist nationalism, rural loyalty, and symbolic power. His rise represented both a continuation and transformation of the Don political tradition: a reconfiguration of lineage-based hegemony through mass populism. Yet beneath this popular unity lay a deeper paradox. The Rajapaksa era reproduced a new dynastic dominance, illustrating that the displacement of Colombo elites did not end Don politics but merely mutated it into a rural, populist form.

The Second Subaltern Power Shift

In 2015, SLFP General Secretary Maithripala Sirisena’s unexpected victory over Mahinda Rajapaksa marked a second subaltern challenge to elite hegemony. Like Premadasa’s ascent, Sirisena’s rise was not merely political but sociological—a moment when lower- and middle-tier actors momentarily captured state power. This transition represented both an elite survival strategy and a counter-elite mobilization. On one hand, figures like Chandrika Kumaratunga and Ranil Wickremesinghe sought to preserve the remnants of the Don order by aligning with a non-threatening outsider. On the other, Sirisena’s candidacy embodied a collective desire to dismantle that very order. His presidency thus became a symbolic synthesis of two contradictory forces.

Sirisena, like Premadasa, lacked aristocratic lineage or elite education. His father, a poor farmer and former soldier under D. S. Senanayake’s colonization scheme, had settled in Polonnaruwa. Without the advantages of elite birth or urban connections, Sirisena’s elevation was enabled by a cross-class coalition: Chandrika and Ranil’s liberal elite networks, Tamil and Muslim minorities, urban professionals, youth movements, and a segment of rural Sinhala-Buddhists. However, instead of realizing those two expectations, what actually happened was that the non-elite President abandoned the social forces that had brought him to power and gradually moved closer to the Mahinda Rajapaksa camp. Nevertheless, by the time this study was conducted in 2016, *Don politics* had already begun to show signs of decline, fragmentation, and disintegration due to various reasons. The factors contributing to this situation, as identified through the qualitative data and thematic analysis, are presented in Table 01.

Table 1. Changes in Elite Politics

Cause	Responses	Percentage
Traditional elite-class politics reached final stage	41	35%
End of family-centered politics	31	26%
Loss of land-based dominance	20	17%
No emergence of a new elite class combining economic, political, and social capital	17	14%
New wealth holders did not enter direct politics	9	8%
Total	118	100%

Source: Research Data, 2016

The Decline of Party Based Elite Dominance**Table 2. Changes in Political Party System**

Cause	Responses Percentage	
All political parties weakened	17	15%
Policy frameworks erased	12	11%
Destruction of leftist parties	18	16%
Unclear second-tier leadership	22	19%
Potential emergence of new forces	14	12%
Emergence of charismatic leaders	8	7%
End of small party presence	23	20%
Total	97	100%

Source: Research Data, 2016

A major finding of this study is that the prolonged personalist hegemony within state institutions contributed significantly to the weakening of traditional party structures. As Table 2 demonstrates, 20% of respondents indicated that small parties had effectively ceased to exist, while 16% observed the destruction of certain political parties, and 15% reported that all parties had become weak. Consequently, by 2016, 51% acknowledged the weakening of the Sri Lankan party system.

Here, ‘weakening’ primarily refers to the collapse of party structures and mechanisms and the decline in cohesion among party members. Historical examples include the destruction of the SLFP and UNP party structures during periods of leadership disruption, notably following electoral defeats in 1977 and 1980, highlighting how elite-driven interventions can destabilize party machinery.

Unclear Second Tier Leadership

The absence of a clear second-tier leadership in all parties contributed to uncertainty in succession and party functioning. Established elite leaders often withheld opportunities for emerging leaders, leaving second-tier figures either unrecognized or excluded, resulting in attrition among potentially capable actors. Pareto’s theory of elite circulation elucidates that when ruling elites are removed, the most competent among subordinates may rise to power. Typically, this process occurs gradually, but obstructions may lead to abrupt or revolutionary changes. Historical examples in Sri Lanka include 1956, 1971, 1977, and youth movements of 1986–89, illustrating intermittent elite replacement. Similarly, Gramsci’s perspective emphasizes that intellectuals from various strata can only emerge as leaders when aligned with ruling or aspiring elites (Newton, 2001). In Sri Lanka, second-tier leadership is frequently stifled by existing elites, preventing systematic elite renewal.

The sudden rise of popular leaders

When party structures are weak and second-tier leadership is unclear, political prominence shifts from party to individual. Qualitative data indicate that new leaders often emerge through popularity, media exposure, or mass appeal rather than institutional merit. Reality TV and celebrity culture provide analogies, reflecting how socio-political conditions favor the rise of individuals from non-traditional backgrounds. This environment enables the emergence of ‘superstars’ within politics who leverage economic, social, and political context to achieve prominence.

Within this study, the “Determinate Time” refers to a historically and politically significant moment that emerges when existing social, economic, and political conditions converge to create the most appropriate opportunity for decisive action in relation to leadership and hegemony. It is not a sudden or accidental occurrence, but a moment consciously and strategically constructed through ongoing political awareness and action. Such a moment may appear to arise from short-term political changes, yet it is deeply rooted in long-term historical and structural foundations. In this sense, it corresponds to Gramsci’s idea of an “organic crisis”—a phase when the existing hegemonic order loses its moral and intellectual authority, creating space for new forces to rise. At the same time, it echoes Foucault’s notion of historical contingency, where established power relations and discourses become destabilized, allowing new forms of knowledge and authority to emerge. Thus, the Determinate Time represents the critical point at which accumulated contradictions and possibilities mature into a conscious and decisive act of transformation a moment when the necessary change or revolution is deliberately realize

Table 3. Concept of the Determinate Time

Potential Change	Responses Percentage	
Significant change or revolutionary shift	31	42%
Emergence of new leaders, parties, or alliances	23	31%
Voter behavior may be influenced	13	18%
Military dominance or youth uprising possible	7	9%
Total	74	100%

Source: Research Data, 2016

Political change in Sri Lanka is shaped not only by immediate events but by long-term structural, economic, and social forces. Instability therefore reflects deeper systemic dynamics rather than isolated incidents. The roots of “Don politics” trace back to the Portuguese arrival in 1505, which enabled certain govi-gama landlord groups in both the Upcountry and Low Country to consolidate power. Through colonial co-optation, mid-level families such as the Salagama, Karava, Durawa, and Nawandanna rose to the Mudaliyar class and gradually formed an elite “Don” stratum. From 1931 onward, this elite became formally integrated into state governance and continued its dominance up to 2024.

Leaders such as R. Premadasa (1988), D. B. Wijetunga (1993), and Maithripala Sirisena (2015) emerged from within this elite structure, but their leadership did not fundamentally alter the personalized, elite-driven Don political system. A major challenge to this order emerged only in 2022 with the Public Struggle Movement (Podujana Aragala). The People’s Liberation Front—established in 1964 and defeated in 1971 and 1986–89—shifted to democratic politics after 1990. By the 2019 parliamentary elections, it had gained about one-third of the vote and mounted a decisive challenge to Don politics, laying the foundation for a subordinate-based administrative model.

Conclusion

The “2022 struggle” marks a historically significant moment in Sri Lanka, not because a single group initiated it, but because it reflected decades of accumulated public dissatisfaction with Don politics since 1947. The 2024 presidential and parliamentary elections showed that this was not merely a change in leaders or parties; it represented the first major defeat of Don politics and the emergence of a governance model oriented toward broad public representation rather than elite control.

Pareto’s *Theory of the Circulation of Elites* (1916) explains that elites resist pressure from subordinate groups, yet social stability requires the upward mobility of subordinates and the displacement of elites. When this process is blocked,

violent upheavals may occur. In Sri Lanka, attempts by the People's Liberation Front in 1971 and 1986–89 reflected this upward movement but took violent forms due to prevailing socio-cultural and religious conditions. These were suppressed through large-scale elimination of young subordinate challengers. In contrast, the 2022 movement succeeded because it transformed into a mass civic mobilization rather than a violent revolution, culminating in the 2024 elections where popular will enabled a peaceful transfer of power.

A clearer theoretical interpretation emerges through Antonio Gramsci's (1971) concept of intellectuals. Gramsci distinguishes between traditional intellectuals, who defend existing class and political structures, and organic intellectuals, who arise from subordinate groups to build new cultural and political leadership. Newton Gunasekera (1971; 1986) further identifies rural organic intellectuals (such as teachers and priests) and urban ones (including academics, artists, and media professionals). The 2022 struggle involved both groups—across ethnic, religious, and youth collectives—who generated new ideas to confront socio-economic and political pressures, thus shaping alternative forms of leadership grounded in public experience and consent.

Sociologically, the actors who came to power in 2024 can be viewed as subordinary in the sense described by Ranjit Guha (1986): groups seeking to reclaim historical visibility erased by elite-dominated narratives. Although elements of the old Don political order remained, the 2024 outcome cannot be simply interpreted as party replacement, socialist rise, or a liberal-to-socialist shift. Nor does it signify full subordinate-class command over the state. Don politics has been significantly weakened but not permanently eliminated, and future elections may allow a reconfiguration or resurgence of elite influence in new forms.

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